

# CECILIA PAYNE-GAPOSCHKIN

1900-1979

Cecilia Payne-Gaposchkin was a brilliant female astronomer. In 1925, after analysing the light from stars using an instrument called a spectrometer, she started to understand what stars were made of. She discovered that they largely consisted of hydrogen, now known to be the most common element in the Universe.

Cecilia **studied at Cambridge in the 1920s** - a time when women were not awarded degrees.

## DATA FILE



**KEY DISCOVERY:** Established that stars are mainly made of hydrogen



**COUNTRY OF ORIGIN:** UK



**YEAR OF ACHIEVEMENT:** 1925